Notwithstanding this, I had asked the ADC to carry some champagne for the occasion, which I could share with my personal staff. At that time, none of us had any inkling that we would have very high-ranking visitors in our midst on that day.

As it happened, I invited the defence minister and my chief and the other senior officers to join me for a drink in my caravan in the evening. As I opened the champagne bottle, I ardently hoped that the cork would pop out with the typical, conversation-stopping sound of good champagne, and it did! It was a Moet et Chandon, which had been chilled in the mini-refrigerator in my caravan. I can say without any hesitation that I would have done the same even if we were in the midst of a war, if the situation permitted. In the event, everyone joined in raising a toast to Rohini and me. One amongst this elite, who professed to be a no-alcohol type, made an exception that evening. Was it for felicitating me or double standards, I wondered. It turned out to be a perfect evening, and a wonderful way to end a hot and hectic day. I missed Rohini very much and told her so when I spoke to her later in the night.

As soon as I saw off the minister and the chief and the other brass the next morning, I asked for a briefing on the progress of the exercise. I was happy to learn from the director that everything was on course, barring a few minor hiccups. Except for the unfortunate air crash, there had been no other mishap. I then told them that I would like to fly to the area where the parachute battalion was air-dropped at night, and meet the troops.

We took off in the light Cheetah helicopter and after about half an hour we were over the area where the para battalion should have attacked. We couldn't see any activity. When we eventually landed in the midst of the defences of the para battalion, I was shocked to see the men crouching in shallow trenches. It was a comical sight, as the burly paratroopers tried to fold themselves into the small dugouts. It was unbelievable that during the last 12 hours they had dug for themselves only knee-deep pits! The fact was that they didn't expect anyone to visit them, least of all the corps commander. It was but natural that I blew my top, and gave the commanding officer the dressing down of his lifetime. If it had happened during